

Letter -- Aiden McCarthy to Kenji Alford

January 22, 2026

Kenji,

I have been meaning to write this out properly for a few weeks and keep not doing it because the mornings get away from me. So here it is.

You probably know the third baker question has been sitting in my head since last spring. I have a Notion doc on it. I have talked to Tamara about it. I ran the numbers with Maya. What I have not done is ask you directly what you think, and I should have done that first.

So here is the question: if we hired a third part-time baker starting next spring, what would that change for you?

I am not asking this as a trap or a test. I am asking because you are the one who would work alongside whoever we hire, and because your answer is going to matter more to whether this works than any spreadsheet I can build.

Here is where I am at. The bakery is not breaking down. You have covered every shift I have asked you to cover and then some. But I know the holiday stretch puts real pressure on both of us, and I know you have been on the morning line six days in December the last two years. I do not think that is sustainable at the level we need to run this place long-term. And I am not just talking about your schedule. I mean mine too. I have not taken a real Monday off since October.

The case for hiring: it gives us a buffer. It means neither of us is one bad week away from the whole thing wobbling. It means I can take a vacation with Nate that does not end with me checking my phone every four hours.

The case against: labor cost. We do not have slack in the budget to absorb a third wage unless we either grow revenue or I stop drawing the same amount. Neither of those is a comfortable answer right now. The holiday season and the Broad Street Grounds account are supposed to tell me whether the revenue case is there.

What I want to know from you:

1. Do you think the kitchen needs a third person, or do you think we can keep running the way we are running?
2. Is there anything about how I am managing the schedule or the workflow that is making your Saturdays harder than they need to be? Anything you have not said because I was always in the middle of something?
3. If we did hire someone, what would you want me to look for? Skill set, personality, whatever. You are going to be on the floor with them every day.

You do not have to answer this in writing. We can talk at the end of a shift. I am just putting it down this way so you have time to think without me standing there waiting for a reaction.

Thank you for everything this year. I mean that.

Aiden